

Second Exam Answers

The Culture of Business, Finance and the Economy

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Instructions: Answer **4 questions** in total: at least 3 from questions 1–6 and no more than 1 from questions 7–9. This document prepares 4 answers: **Q1** (option B), **Q2**, **Q3** (mandatory group) and **Q7** (elective group).

Question 1 — The Self as Business (Class XVII)

Question: *Discussing its emergence and characteristics, characterise the “self as business” and show its workings in TCBFE as thoroughly as possible and with as many class examples as possible.*

To understand how the self became a business, one must first trace how the very concept of selfhood evolved in relation to work. In antiquity, “being yourself” was a matter of property — owning your house, your land, your possessions. With the industrial revolution, the self became something different: a **property** that could be rented out to a factory or a firm for a specific purpose. Two features defined this arrangement. First, **exclusivity**: the worker committed to one employer, and the employer reciprocated with loyalty. “You are mine for decades to come” was the implicit contract. Labour was scarce, so companies encouraged long-term commitment through stable pay, insurance, promotions, and what amounted to **treats as rewards for loyalty**. Firms even offered “pay-to-stay” bonuses to retain workers. Second, there were clear **boundaries**: work happened from 9 to 5, and you lived your life outside of that boundary. What you did after hours was your own affair.

The contemporary shift dismantled both pillars. The self is no longer a property to be rented — it has become a **business**. “I am a bundle of skills, assets and experiences that must be managed and constantly enhanced.” Tom Peters captured this perfectly in his 1997 *Fast Company* article: “We are the CEOs of our own companies: Me Inc.” To be employable now means to *represent yourself as a business* — with experiences, skills, and personality as your product line.

Loyalty was replaced by passion. Loyalty was a two-way street: be loyal to someone and they are loyal back, build together. Passion, by contrast, is an individual value. If you do not have passion, you will not get the job. For passion, companies no longer offer houses or mortgages — they offer health chatbots, gym memberships, and discounts. You are *no longer an employee*; you become a “**collaborator**” because you “work together” — two businesses collaborating with each other. Companies now pay people to leave (“pay-to-quit”) because loyalty matters so little. Consistently, no exclusivity is expected or offered any more.

Boundaries are dead. Since we are expected to be available on demand and always “on,” whatever we do outside working hours affects our professional standing. The Coldplay kiss cam incident discussed in class illustrates this perfectly: a moment of personal life broadcast publicly can have professional consequences. There is no longer a protected private sphere.

The self-as-business manifests concretely in four ways. First, **skills**: historically, skills were unambiguous, linear, concrete, and job-related. Now, things all humans do — like communication, replying to emails, maintaining a personal tone — have been “assetized.” Speaking and listening became a “skill.” You are expected to know and rank your skills as if they were product features. Second, **CVs and LinkedIn**: when we were property, a CV was a historical record of what you had done. Now a resume is no longer that — it is a **marketing document**. We no longer tell people what we do; we present metrics and results. Back in the day, references and grades would have done the same job. Third, **personal brand**: if you are your own CEO, you are the brand. Since staying at a company has no value and people switch jobs constantly, people must **craft a narrative about their work history** for recruiters. The cohesiveness of that narrative is crucial. Fourth, **networking**: there are far too many jobs and too much demand. Employers increasingly automatize CV reception through **applicant tracking systems**, which are designed to manage workload, not find the best candidate. Networking becomes crucial to bypass these systems because your contacts know you.

The workings of the self-as-business permeate TCBFE broadly. The Entrepreneurial Self discussed in Class XVI — with its five historical strands of professional expectations, transferable skills, embracing uncertainty, managerialism, and human capital — provides the *disposition* that makes the self-as-business possible. Schultz’s concept of “human capital” (1961) reframed labour *towards* capital: skills and knowledge *are* a form of capital produced by deliberate investment. Uber’s slogan “Be Your Own Boss” captures this logic perfectly. The body itself becomes an asset: as the HBR article by Liane Davey argued, sleep, nutrition, and exercise should be framed not as personal needs but as **investments** — “if you are an important asset, how could depriving and depreciating that asset possibly be good for your organization?” Even personal trauma and grief become monetizable raw material: Medium articles on “Monetizing Your Grief, Struggles, and Trauma,” China’s “sympathy economy” of livestreamers selling through personal tragedy, and TED talks reframing trauma as resilience all illustrate how everything in one’s biography becomes material for the entrepreneurial self-as-business. The EU Youth Portal even presents volunteering as building “transferable skills” for “better job prospects.”

The self-as-business is, in the end, a thorough colonization of personhood by business logic — where loyalty yields to passion, boundaries dissolve, and every aspect of who you are becomes a manageable, optimizable, marketable asset.

Question 2 — From Makerspaces to Venture Capitalism: The Very Beginnings (Class XVIII)

Question: *Retrace the very beginnings of the journey from makerspaces to venture capitalism as thoroughly as possible and with as many class examples as possible.*

The journey from makerspaces to venture capitalism begins, as Silvia Lindtner documents in her ethnography *Prototype Nation*, in the early 2000s with a particular kind of space and ethos. Hackerspaces, makerspaces, and hackathons emerged as sites of **playful experimentation** — fun and flexible, organized around peer production and community. They were chaotic, unscripted, unruly. The core promise was a shift **from being a consumer to being a maker, a producer** — someone who can make stuff, whether tote bags or software. The defining spirit was “playing for playing’s sake.”

This culture was vibrant but, crucially, uncommercial. People gathered to tinker, learn, and share. Then, as Lindtner observed, around 2011 a recurring topic in the hacker and maker spaces where she had been embedded since 2008 was how to “**take things to the next level**” and to “**scale up**.” This was the pivotal moment: the transition from making for its own sake to making for the market.

The institutional vehicle for this transition was the **incubator**. Startup incubator programs are structured and intensive initiatives designed to support and nurture early-stage startup companies. They provide entrepreneurs with resources, guidance, and mentorship to help them grow their businesses. The key features are: a competitive application process selecting only the most promising startups; physical workspace fostering collaboration; access to resources; mentoring and guidance from experienced entrepreneurs and investors; networking opportunities connecting startups with a diverse network of investors and industry professionals; workshops and educational programs; funding and investment opportunities through partnerships with venture capitalists and angel investors; peer support and collaboration with like-minded entrepreneurs; a time-limited structure that creates urgency; and graduation with ongoing support.

What is crucial about incubators, from the perspective of this course, is that they appeared to **retain the commitment to playful experimentation, fun and flexible work culture, peer production, and community** that many had come to identify with maker and hacker culture. The same enthusiasm, the same “having fun,” but the promise was now to connect this culture of tinkering to “the real world.” The critical switch into entrepreneurship required learning how to **derive pleasure not only from hacking machines but from hacking markets**. Incubators, in this sense, are “start-up schools” that “**coin entrepreneurs first and ideas later**.” Chris Anderson’s book *Makers: The New Industrial Revolution* celebrated this very promise.

Lindtner’s ethnography of a Shenzhen incubator — three months in the prototyping capital of China — illustrates the next step. UCHINA, based in Troublemaker, a makerspace located in Huaqiangbei (the world’s largest electronics market), ran a hardware acceleration program that promised to move products from concept to mass production in months rather than years. Shenzhen was enriched with a sense of **speed** — it promised to teach people how to accelerate. The logic was clear: by “accelerating” the time it takes to bring a new product to market, one increases one’s attractiveness to investors. The start-up can only compete with traditional “economies of scale” by stepping outside their dependency on product sales and **attracting finance capital**.

On the second day of the Shenzhen program, Peter O’Melly, CEO of the Western venture capital firm that had funded the incubator, gave his famous “rocket-fuel speech” — a motivational, deliberately personal talk modelling the entrepreneur as confident, survivalist, optimist, interventionist. “As entrepreneurs, we are high up at the chain of life, because we self-actualize,” he declared. The 3H Personality Theory — Hustler, Hacker, and Hipster — codified the ideal startup founding team.

The program trained teams to attract two audiences: **capital investors** (through pitches) and a **potential consumer base** (via crowdfunding platforms like Kickstarter and Indiegogo). Crucially, the crowdfunding campaigns were **not actually designed to sell products or raise money**. Most hardware start-ups barely break even or even lose money from crowdfunding sales. Their real purpose was to show the product had a potential market. Investors look for these indicators to minimize their risks. A successful campaign shows the promise of future gains, of enhancements to investors’ portfolios. As Lindtner puts it in a line that captures the entire trajectory: “**The start-ups were taught to produce not products to be sold, but promises to be invested in.**”

This is where makerspaces end and venture capitalism begins. Incubators and accelerators channel the maker spirit of speed, scale, and magnitude directly towards venture capital — transforming playful tinkerers into investable entrepreneurs, and prototypes into promissory vehicles for financial return.

Question 3 — Hype, Pitching, Leveraging, and Venture Capitalism (Class XIX)

Question: *Describe the workings of “hype, pitching and leveraging” and the main features of venture capitalism as thoroughly as possible and with as many examples from class as possible.*

Hype is not about truth or falsity, but about **credibility or incredibility**. It is a **credible, fabricated truth** that entrepreneurs and investors work toward — rather than a fabricated lie meant to defraud and deceive. Hype becomes a way for imagining the future and working to enact that future. The example of Incyte and the Human Genome Project illustrates this perfectly. At the Eleventh International Human Genome Sequencing and Analysis Conference in Miami (1999), Dr. Randy Scott, president and chief scientific officer of Incyte, announced an estimate of 140,000 human genes — a sharp upward revision from Dr. Craig Venter’s earlier estimate of 60,000–80,000. Incyte scientists estimated 130,000 genes using one method and 143,000 using another, averaging to 140,000. We now know humans have about 26,000–30,000 genes. The product of a genome company is the creation of *information* that is a condition of possibility for the creation of a drug. The conditions of its own possibility can only be created through a *vision*. This is why the **vision of the future creates the conditions of possibility for the existence of the company in the present**. Visions do not even have to be true to sell. Scott finished his talk with a poignant personal story about a friend recently diagnosed with cancer who, ten years later, “could have been saved by genomics.” At that perfectly orchestrated moment, Scott broke down and cried. The key insight: “start-ups were taught to produce not products to be sold, but **promises to be invested in**.”

Pitching is the performative art through which hype is delivered to investors. The STHLM Tech Meetup in Stockholm — Europe’s largest monthly gathering of startups, with top angel investors and VC firms like EQT, Creandum, Northzone, Norrsken, and Techstars — exemplifies the ecosystem where pitches happen. The “Forests!” pitch by Per and Jonna (Vandenbroek) is a perfect case study of how pitching works and fails. Two entrepreneurs pitched their startup to a VC panel, opening with a somber story about an endangered forest-dwelling species, talking about forests and climate change. The moderator interrupted when the animal reappeared on the fourth slide: “Oh, this guy again!” Their actual product was a social logbook mobile app for amateur naturalists that crowdsourced data for research. The moderator cut them off: “Let’s pause there because I think we are about to get to the good stuff.” The VCs reacted: “How do they make money?” “I still don’t know what they do.” One VC said: “This has potential. But you’ve told me a nice story about conservation. And that is not what I need to hear. What **I need is the core of your business**; the conservation is a nice side effect you can mention on the side.” Another added: “An investor has to know how they are going to **get their money back**.” The correct pitch, according to VCs, would be: “I’ve built a great app that **people love to use**. It’s a digital record book for hikers, birders, whatever — it has **social stuff, gamification, it’s addicting, people want to pay to use it**. How do I know? Because **we already have ten thousand users**. And we can use the data to save the planet by giving it to scientists.” An investor shouted: “I would give you money for that!”

Leveraging means borrowing money from lenders, banks, or investors — **taking on risk in order to do business with resources that one does not own** for the sake of speed and flexibility to take things further. The economy built on leveraging is a “**gyroscope economy**”: it cannot balance unless spun fast. Make it or leave. Junyi’s story (Wong) is the most detailed class example. Junyi and his classmate began making robot prototypes to pitch to investors. During a break in China, a VC firm offered a significant amount of money for a small stake in their startup — which *did not yet have a saleable product*. They worked frantically, burning through their “**burn rate**” — the speed at which they were using up liquidity hiring employees and prototyping iterations. Their original VCs referred them to “Big Tech1” (a major tech company

with a VC arm). Ben, head of the VC arm, invited them to demo a unit on campus and specified requirements: clear debris, sort rubbish, operate via remote control, avoid obstacles, cope with uneven ground and steps. Junyi agreed — *his team had no idea if they could even achieve that*. They met other potential investors who knew Junyi’s original VC and knew Big Tech1 had shown interest. Junyi could not yet secure contracts, but he extracted “**letters of intent**” — stating that should he secure express intent from Big Tech1, they would want the robots too. Leveraging his VC’s and Big Tech1’s reputation, Junyi established **conditional ties** — like crowdfunding, no actual money. As demo day approached, they hit a snag: signal interference between the robot’s GPS sensor and Wi-Fi receiver. On demo day, the issue was unresolved. Big Tech1 employees crowded around. In utter panic, the engineers huddled around the robot, shielding it from view. One engineer gave it a hearty thump — it worked, and the robot operated perfectly for the few minutes of the demo. Shortly after, Junyi received a letter from Big Tech1 expressing willingness to station robots on their campus *if* they fulfilled certain requirements within a stated timeline. As word got out, more letters of intent came in. Junyi used these to knock on VC doors. Given this “surge” in interested consumers (a proxy for “demand”), Junyi’s team secured more VC funding and narrowly avoided implosion. This “growth hacking” was a **virtuoso display of craftiness** — even though Junyi was not technologically capable of producing the robot, he was *artfully* leveraging social relationships, money, risk, reputation, and credibility to hold this *fabricated truth* together until the day he would become technologically accountable.

As for the main features of **venture capitalism**: VC investors have a **responsibility to grow their fund** through investments that will **scale their valuations exponentially** over the term of investment. Even VCs who care deeply about climate change have little to offer as an ally on that matter alone — what they need is the core of the business, growth potential, and a path to getting their money back. Hype, pitching, and leveraging together constitute an *ethos that seizes our rationality from beyond* — a logic of credible futures, performed promises, and leveraged relationships that sustains the startup world.

Question 7 — Consultants’ Abstractions (Class XIII)

Question: *Discuss: “The abstractions consultants produce and deal with perpetuate the need for their involvement and deflect responsibility.”*

The central concept through which this statement operates is what Stein calls **profitable uncertainty**. Profitable uncertainty is the idea that consultants benefit from — and actively cultivate — uncertainty. It is both a *kind of speech* and a *kind of orientation* toward the future. Uncertainty is not a problem to be solved but a resource to be exploited: it justifies the consultant’s presence, generates new engagements, and keeps clients dependent.

Stein identifies three mechanisms through which consultants make uncertainty profitable, and each of them produces abstractions that perpetuate involvement and deflect responsibility. First, **potential worlds**: consultants construct possible future scenarios — some desirable, some threatening — that make the client feel the need for expert guidance. By painting vivid alternative futures, they create urgency and justify action. These scenarios are, by definition, abstractions — they do not describe reality but possible realities, and they position the consultant as the one who can navigate between them. Second, **free decisions**: consultants present *options, not suggestions*. This shifts the burden of decision to the client while allowing the consultant to hedge against failure. If things go wrong, it was the client’s choice. The abstraction here is the framing of consulting work as the production of “options” rather than recommendations — a rhetorical device that simultaneously produces value (the options) and deflects responsibility (the choice was yours). Third, **consultant engagement**: the ongoing relationship itself becomes the product. Uncertainty never fully resolves, so the consultant is always needed for the next step. The abstraction of “engagement” perpetuates the need for continued involvement

by design.

The “Over the Edge” project in Linnfjell illustrates all three mechanisms at work. A small Norwegian town (Syndinfjeld area) where the local industry (Norindustry) had historically taken care of everything hired consultants — for the third time — to help envision a future. Six seminars, three hours each, costing 45,000 USD, with participants including local government, union reps, high school students, businesspeople, and NGOs. The consultant Pettersen asked what a thriving community needed. Participants answered “jobs” or “night clubs.” Pettersen redirected: a *positive attitude* was crucial. “You need faith to make it happen!” When someone asked about money (investments), Pettersen responded: “don’t say money, say *strategy*. Strategy is created where there is energy, and energy is found where there is hope.” This is a masterful example of abstraction perpetuating involvement: by replacing concrete material needs (money, jobs) with abstract ones (strategy, energy, hope, attitude), the consultant makes the engagement about something that can never be definitively achieved or measured.

Four future scenarios were constructed: “Alp Village” (tourism), “Neo-industrial Growth” (R&D on renewable energy), “The Green Valley” (conservation and sustainable agriculture), and “Miserable Linnfjell” (continued decline). A local businessman, Torstein Moen, grew so inspired he quit his job. But then the project ended — the end product was a 77-slide PowerPoint. The final presentation leaned toward “Alp Village,” so the “Green Valley” group complained. And Moen was now jobless. Pettersen’s defense: the presentation was not what mattered most, but whether the project “succeeded in opening their eyes to new possibilities, whether it inspired and motivated them and fostered a sense of community among them.” This is precisely how abstractions deflect responsibility — the outcome is reframed from concrete deliverables (a plan, jobs, investments) to abstract ones (opened eyes, inspiration, community feeling), which cannot be falsified.

“**The Gap**” is another powerful abstraction. The word “gap” is widely used in consulting — even included in company names. Consultants constantly invoke revenue gaps, performance gaps, knowledge gaps. These are illustrated with charts and shapes comparing an entity to a *potential state*. The gap simultaneously diagnoses a problem and implies a solution. Gaps can be “bridged,” “filled,” or “closed” — and doing so requires the consultant’s expertise. The purpose is to present to the client a potential world that is *just* out of reach, perpetuating the need for the consultant who alone can close it.

The Profit Acquisition Letter (PAL) exemplifies this: a consulting engagement with an African government where the PAL outlined potential revenue gains the consultant could help capture, identifying “gaps” between current and potential revenue and positioning the consultant as the one who can close them. Even McKinsey’s report *Automotive Revolution — Perspective Towards 2030* uses the same rhetoric: “Prepare for uncertainty,” “A sophisticated level of scenario planning and agility is required.” Uncertainty is not merely acknowledged but *prescribed* — it becomes an orientation that demands more consulting.

In sum, the abstractions consultants produce — potential worlds, free decisions, engagement, gaps, strategy, energy — form a self-reinforcing system. They create a language in which problems can never be fully solved (because they are defined in unmeasurable terms), solutions always require further consulting (because uncertainty never resolves), and responsibility for failure always lies elsewhere (because the consultant only offered options, not directions). The abstractions are not a by-product of consulting work; they are its core technology.